represent only one part of the story. How were the words set down on rock communicated to the people of the locality? This was done by a specially designated official through a public reading in which those who had congregated at the place of inscription were required to listen. So, even if Ashoka's message was inscribed, its dissemination was oral.[18] That orality was central to this spectacle is evident from the proclamatory 'Devanampiya speaks thus', a phrase frequently encountered. It draws attention to the fact that what had been written had first been spoken, and that the speaker, being the emperor, had to be carefully listened to. Living in faraway Pataliputra, the monarch was compensating for his absence in most of his empire by speaking to his subjects via intermediaries who were standing in for him via reading out his utterances. The interplay of orality and textuality also raises the question of whether the message was read as it appeared on the rock, or from a copy that the reader-communicator fished out of from the folds of his clothes or his bag. In the case of a site like Maski, the edict was inscribed in a fairly compact way and could be read fairly easily. This was not at all so everywhere. At Siddapura, for instance, it would have been impossible for the official to position himself in the very restricted space that separated the engraved rock from an overhanging boulder. So, in such places, a written exemplar was almost certainly used.